

EmpowerED

Word Train Showdown — Teacher Guide

Age group	Grade 1–5
Class size	Any
Time	15–25 min
Materials	None

Overview

Word Train Showdown turns phonics practice into a fast-paced team competition. Students stand in two teams and take turns saying words from a chosen word family. The train keeps moving as long as students respond correctly without repeating words or hesitating. The game builds quick recall, listening skills, teamwork, and confidence.

Setup

1. Split the class into 2 teams standing in lines facing each other
2. Teacher chooses the phonics category before the round begins
3. Start with easy word families students already know
4. No materials are needed — this is a speaking game
5. Teacher acts as the train conductor and controls the pace

How to Play

1. Teacher announces a word family: Example: '-at family!'
2. Team 1 begins by saying a valid word from that family
3. The first student from Team 2 immediately responds with another valid word
4. Teams continue alternating words back and forth like a moving train
5. Students cannot repeat previously used words
6. If a student says an incorrect word, repeats a word, or stays silent for more than 5 seconds, the train crashes
7. The opposing team earns 1 point
8. Teacher immediately starts the next round with the same or a different family

Switch Track Examples

Teacher says	What changes
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SWITCH TRACK — MAGIC E!	Students must now say Magic E words
SWITCH TRACK — OO WORDS!	Students switch to OO sound words
SWITCH TRACK — BLENDS!	Students switch to blend words

Example Rally

Team 1	Team 2
cat	bat
hat	mat
rat	sat
pat	Silence... TRAIN CRASH

Volunteer Tips

1. Keep the game moving quickly to maintain excitement
2. Use dramatic countdowns: '5... 4... 3...'
3. Celebrate long rallies loudly to build energy
4. Start with easier families before introducing harder categories
5. Use Switch Track sparingly so it feels exciting
6. Encourage teams to think ahead while waiting for their turn

Differentiation

For beginners: Use only one word family per round and allow students extra thinking time. Teachers can also display example words on the board.

For advanced students: Introduce Switch Track rounds suddenly and use harder categories like blends, digraphs, or mixed phonics patterns.

Quick Reference

Family	Example words
-at	cat, bat, hat, mat, rat
-og	dog, log, fog, jog
-in	pin, tin, bin, fin
Magic E	cape, kite, hope
OO words	moon, spoon, book, cook

